

CULTS AND THE GOSPEL

Biblical Discernment, Christian Doctrine, and Pastoral Response

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Editorial and Method Note

This textbook was prepared for Chapala Theological Seminary as a companion to the existing Cults course. It is not a duplication of the course lessons. The course supplies biblical and theological coordinates; this book develops a framework for discernment, historical case studies, and pastoral application.

The word cult is used cautiously. Whenever possible, a movement's present beliefs are described from its own official sources before they are evaluated from the standpoint of historic Christian doctrine and Scripture. Individual members may not know or affirm every official teaching.

This book distinguishes theological error from abusive control. A group can be doctrinally orthodox in many respects and still misuse authority; a group can be peaceful and socially healthy while teaching doctrines that historic Christianity regards as false. Students should evaluate both questions without confusing them.

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Core Diagnostic Questions

- What is the final authority?
- Who is God?
- Who is Jesus Christ?
- What is the human problem?
- How is a person reconciled to God?

1. Another Jesus, Another Spirit, Another Gospel

The New Testament problem

The New Testament church did not live in a world without religious counterfeits. Jesus warned about false prophets. Paul warned the Ephesian elders that destructive teachers could arise even from among the church's own leaders. John told believers to test the spirits. Peter and Jude warned that false teachers could use Christian language while corrupting Christian truth.

Galatians 1:6-9 gives this study its controlling principle. Paul is astonished that believers are turning to a different gospel. He then removes one of the easiest excuses for accepting new religious claims: impressive credentials do not make a false gospel true. Paul says that even if an apostle or an angel from heaven proclaims a gospel contrary to the one already received, that message is to be rejected.

Second Corinthians 11:3-4 gives another useful diagnostic. Paul warns about another Jesus, a different spirit, and a different gospel. Christian discernment therefore asks more than whether a group uses the Bible, speaks about Jesus, or describes itself as Christian. The important questions are: Which Jesus? What gospel? What authority defines them?

Not every disagreement is another gospel

Christians disagree about many important matters. Baptists and Presbyterians differ about baptism. Christians disagree about church government, spiritual gifts, election, the millennium, worship style, and other doctrines. Those disagreements can be serious without creating a different religion.

The strongest New Testament warnings concern teachings that overturn the identity of God and Christ, replace the apostolic gospel, deny the saving work of Christ, or establish a rival authority capable of correcting the gospel itself. This course therefore avoids using the word cult as a weapon for every group with which we disagree.

A pastoral purpose

The purpose of studying cults is not to produce suspicious Christians who see enemies everywhere. It is to produce discerning Christians who know the gospel well enough to recognize a substitute and love people well enough to speak truth without ridicule. The person at your door, in your family, or in your congregation is not a theological specimen. He or she is a person for whom Christ died.

2. What Do We Mean by Cult?

A difficult word

The word cult has several meanings. Sociologists may use it differently from theologians, and popular speech often uses it for any strange or controlling group. Because the word can become an insult, this textbook uses it cautiously.

For our theological purpose, a cult-like Christian movement is one that claims Christian identity or biblical authority while substantially redefining one or more essentials of the historic apostolic faith—especially God, Christ, the gospel, or final religious authority. Some groups also display unhealthy social control, but control and doctrinal error are different questions and should not be confused.

Four levels of disagreement

It helps to distinguish four categories. First are ordinary Christian differences: matters on which faithful Christians can disagree while sharing the same gospel. Second are serious doctrinal errors that can damage Christian life but do not necessarily replace the gospel. Third is heresy: teaching that contradicts a central Christian confession such as the full deity and humanity of Christ or the triune identity of God. Fourth is a different religious system that uses Christian vocabulary while giving that vocabulary substantially different meanings.

These categories are not mathematical formulas. They are tools for careful thought. The goal is to describe beliefs accurately before evaluating them.

The five diagnostic questions

Throughout this book we will repeatedly ask five questions. What is the final authority? Who is God? Who is Jesus Christ? What is the human problem? How is a person reconciled to God? These questions expose differences that vocabulary alone can hide.

3. Authority: Who Has the Right to Define the Gospel?

Scripture and later revelation

Christianity is a revealed faith. Christians do not invent the gospel; they receive it. The Old and New Testaments bear authoritative witness to God's acts and to Jesus Christ. Second Timothy 3:16-17 describes Scripture as God-breathed and sufficient to equip God's servant for every good work. Jude speaks of the faith entrusted to God's people.

A movement deserves careful examination when it introduces another book, prophet, governing body, inspired interpreter, or revelatory system that can effectively revise the meaning of the biblical gospel. The issue is not whether Christians can learn from teachers. The issue is whether another authority can correct, supersede, or redefine the apostolic witness.

The angel test

Galatians 1 is especially important because several later movements appeal to supernatural restoration. Paul's standard does not ask first whether a messenger is impressive or supernatural. The message itself is tested against the gospel already received. An angelic claim therefore increases the need for discernment; it does not suspend it.

Translation and interpretation

Groups may affirm the Bible while interpreting familiar passages through a distinctive doctrinal system. Students should therefore avoid a shallow test such as, 'Do they believe the Bible?' A better question is, 'What authority determines what the Bible is allowed to mean?'

4. The Christian Measure: God, Christ, and Salvation

One God, Father, Son, and Holy Spirit

Historic Christianity confesses one God and also confesses the Father, Son, and Holy Spirit as divine. The doctrine of the Trinity was not invented to make Christianity complicated. It arose from the church's attempt to speak faithfully about the whole biblical witness: there

is one God; the Father is God; the Son is God; the Spirit is God; and the Father, Son, and Spirit are personally distinguishable.

A movement may use the words Father, Son, and Holy Spirit while rejecting this confession. The question is therefore not vocabulary but meaning.

The identity of Jesus

The New Testament presents Jesus as truly human and yet more than a creature. John calls the Word God and says the Word became flesh. Thomas addresses the risen Jesus as 'My Lord and my God.' Colossians describes the Son as the one through whom all things were created. Hebrews distinguishes the Son from angels and applies divine language to him.

A reduced Jesus produces a reduced gospel. If Christ is merely a created messenger, enlightened teacher, or example, the meaning of incarnation, atonement, worship, and salvation changes with him.

Grace and the finished work of Christ

The gospel announces what God has done in Christ. Human obedience is the fruit of saving faith, not a price paid to make Christ's work effective. Ephesians 2:8-10 holds grace, faith, and good works together in the proper order. Romans and Galatians strongly resist systems in which human achievement becomes the ground of justification.

When studying any movement, ask whether assurance finally rests in Christ or in Christ plus required achievements, ordinances, institutional loyalty, secret knowledge, or spiritual attainment.

5. The Church of Jesus Christ of Latter-day Saints

Hearing the movement in its own words

Members of The Church of Jesus Christ of Latter-day Saints explicitly identify themselves as Christians and place Jesus Christ at the center of their devotion. Fair evaluation begins there rather than with caricature. Their official teaching describes the Father, Son, and Holy Ghost as three separate divine beings united in purpose. It also teaches that the Father and the Son possess tangible glorified bodies.

The church accepts the Bible but also receives the Book of Mormon, Doctrine and Covenants, and Pearl of Great Price as scripture and recognizes continuing prophetic authority. The Book of Mormon is officially described as another testament of Jesus Christ.

The theological difference

The central disagreement with historic Nicene Christianity is not whether Latter-day Saints say the name Jesus. It concerns the identity of God, the relation of Father, Son, and Spirit, the nature of divine revelation, and the larger plan of exaltation. Latter-day Saint teaching explicitly rejects the post-New Testament creedal understanding of God.

This is exactly why 2 Corinthians 11:4 is useful. Similar vocabulary does not settle identity. Students should compare the actual meanings assigned to God, Christ, grace, salvation, revelation, and eternal life.

How to speak with Latter-day Saints

Do not begin with mockery of temple clothing, family history, missionaries, or disputed anecdotes from church history. Ask gracious questions. Who is God? Has God always been God? What does it mean to become like God? What authority does the Book of Mormon

have? What happens if later revelation appears to conflict with the Bible? What must a sinner do to be reconciled to God?

Keep returning to the biblical identity and sufficiency of Christ. A conversation that wins an argument but closes the person's ears is not a pastoral victory.

6. Jehovah's Witnesses

What they teach

Jehovah's Witnesses describe themselves as Christians and affirm the Bible as God's inspired message. They honor Jesus as Savior and Son of God. At the same time, their official teaching explicitly rejects the Trinity and says that Jesus is not Almighty God. Their literature describes Jesus as the first of God's creations.

They also teach a distinctive understanding of God's Kingdom, Christ's heavenly rule beginning in 1914, and a heavenly group of 144,000, while other faithful people hope for everlasting life on a restored earth.

Why Christology is decisive

The disagreement is not primarily about birthdays, holidays, blood transfusions, or door-to-door evangelism. Those practices may be discussed, but they are not the center. The decisive question is the identity of Jesus Christ.

Historic Christianity confesses the Son as eternally divine, not the highest created being. John 1, Colossians 1, Hebrews 1, Philippians 2, and the worship given to Christ must be read together. Students should learn to discuss these texts in context rather than trading isolated proof texts.

Grace, obedience, and organization

Jehovah's Witness teaching speaks of salvation through Christ's ransom and also stresses faith, changed conduct, baptism, and obedience. Christians likewise teach that genuine faith produces obedience. The important pastoral question is where final confidence rests and how the movement's organizational interpretation governs the believer's understanding of Scripture and salvation.

When speaking with Witnesses, treat them as people rather than projects. Ask them to read whole passages with you. The aim is not to defeat a trained presentation but to bear witness to the biblical Christ.

7. Christian Science

A different use of familiar words

Christian Science, founded by Mary Baker Eddy in the nineteenth century, uses many Christian terms and states that the Bible is its guide. Its official tenets speak of God, Christ, the Holy Ghost, atonement, resurrection, sin, and salvation. Yet these words function within a metaphysical system quite different from historic Christianity.

Christian Science emphasizes God as infinite Spirit and teaches the ultimate reality of Spirit over matter. Its official tenets describe evil as unreal in a distinctive sense and describe Jesus' atonement as revealing humanity's unity with God through Christ Jesus as the Way-shower.

Creation, sin, incarnation, and atonement

Biblical Christianity treats creation as genuinely created by God, human sin as morally real, the incarnation as the Word truly becoming flesh, and Christ's death and resurrection as objective acts of God in history. If matter, evil, sin, incarnation, and atonement are substantially redefined, the gospel narrative itself changes.

Students should therefore resist being reassured merely because Christian vocabulary is present. Again, meaning matters more than labels.

Pastoral sensitivity

Christian Science has a long association with spiritual healing. Conversations about healing can touch painful personal histories, including illness and bereavement. The Christian response should never be ridicule. We can affirm God's power to heal while also affirming the goodness of creation, the reality of suffering, and the historical death and bodily resurrection of Jesus.

8. Seventh-day Adventism: A Necessary Distinction

Why older cult books can mislead

Some older evangelical books classified Seventh-day Adventism alongside movements such as Jehovah's Witnesses and Christian Science. Modern students need greater precision. The contemporary Seventh-day Adventist Church officially affirms the Trinity, the co-eternal Father, Son, and Holy Spirit, the full saving work of Christ, and the Old and New Testaments as the authoritative Word of God.

That does not mean other evangelicals will agree with every Adventist doctrine. Significant differences remain concerning the Sabbath, Ellen G. White's prophetic ministry, the heavenly sanctuary, the investigative judgment, the state of the dead, and other teachings.

Difference is not automatically another gospel

The proper question is whether those differences amount to a denial of the biblical Christ and gospel. Because official contemporary Adventist doctrine confesses central Trinitarian and Christological beliefs shared by historic Christianity, CTS will not simply label all Seventh-day Adventists a cult.

Individual congregations and teachers should still be evaluated by what they actually teach. The same principle applies to Baptists, Pentecostals, Catholics, Methodists, and every other tradition. Labels cannot substitute for discernment.

9. New Revelation, Prophets, and Restoration Claims

The restoration pattern

Many religious movements begin with a restoration story: the true faith was lost, corrupted, hidden, or suppressed, and God has now restored it through a chosen messenger. Such claims are powerful because they explain disagreement in advance. If historic Christianity disagrees with the new prophet, that disagreement itself can be presented as evidence of historic apostasy.

The New Testament certainly calls the church to reform when it departs from truth. But reform returns to the apostolic gospel; it does not require a different gospel.

Testing prophetic claims

First John 4 tells believers to test the spirits. Deuteronomy supplies tests for prophetic claims. Jesus says false prophets are known by their fruit. Paul insists that even supernatural claims remain subordinate to the gospel.

Students should test both doctrine and fruit. A charismatic leader's sincerity, visions, apparent miracles, confidence, or personal sacrifice cannot by themselves establish truth.

When authority becomes control

Doctrinal error and abusive control are not identical, but they can reinforce one another. Warning signs include leaders who cannot be questioned, isolation from family or outside information, manipulation through fear, demands for secrecy, financial exploitation, sexual exploitation, and claims that leaving the group means leaving God.

A church should never use the language of spiritual authority to protect abuse. Biblical shepherding serves the flock; it does not consume it.

10. Other Religions and the Word 'Cult'

Islam and Hinduism are not Christian cults

A course on cults often sits near courses on world religions, and students can confuse the categories. Islam is not a Christian cult in the ordinary theological sense; it is a distinct monotheistic religion that honors Jesus as a prophet while rejecting central Christian claims about his divine sonship and crucifixion. Hindu traditions are likewise not corrupted forms of Christianity but diverse religious traditions with their own histories and concepts of ultimate reality.

We compare these religions with the gospel, but accuracy requires us to name them correctly.

Why the distinction matters

Calling every non-Christian religion a cult makes the term nearly useless. It also prevents students from understanding what people actually believe. Christian witness becomes stronger, not weaker, when it is accurate.

Paul in Acts 17 demonstrates both understanding and disagreement. He observes the religious world around him, identifies points of contact, and then proclaims the Creator, repentance, judgment, and resurrection. He does not need to misrepresent his hearers in order to preach Christ.

11. How Cult-Like Systems Hold People

Belonging before doctrine

People do not remain in religious movements only because of arguments. Family, friendship, identity, fear, hope, marriage, community, and years of sacrifice can all be involved. Leaving may cost a person nearly every important relationship.

A pastor who treats the issue as a puzzle to solve may miss the person standing in front of him. Intellectual questions matter, but so do grief and belonging.

Fear and certainty

High-control systems can offer absolute certainty: the organization alone is safe; outsiders are deceived; doubt is rebellion; leaders possess special access to truth. Such certainty can feel secure, especially during crisis.

The gospel offers confidence of a different kind. Christian assurance rests finally in Christ, not in the perfection of an earthly organization. Leaders can be tested. Churches can repent. Scripture can correct us.

Helping someone leave

Do not demand that a person resolve every doctrine in one conversation. Provide a safe relationship. Read Scripture together. Encourage questions. If there has been abuse or coercive control, involve appropriate professional and legal help. Never tell a victim that protecting an institution is more important than telling the truth.

12. Speaking the Truth in Love

Begin with the gospel

The best preparation for recognizing a counterfeit is deep familiarity with the real thing. Know the biblical story of creation, fall, covenant, incarnation, cross, resurrection, grace, faith, new life, and final restoration. Know who Jesus is.

A Christian who knows only facts about cults can still be easily confused. A Christian who knows the gospel has a center from which to evaluate new claims.

Ask before accusing

Ask people what they believe rather than assuming. Official teaching matters, but individuals may not understand or accept every official doctrine. Questions such as 'What do you mean by that?' and 'How did you come to believe that?' often accomplish more than a rehearsed attack.

Represent another person's belief in a way that the person could recognize as fair. Only then evaluate it.

Keep the essentials central

Conversations can disappear into secondary subjects: holidays, clothing, food, architecture, famous scandals, or obscure historical claims. Sometimes those issues matter, but they can also distract from the central questions.

Return to authority, God, Christ, sin, grace, and salvation. Above all, return to Jesus Christ crucified and risen.

Humility in discernment

Christians can also misuse authority, manipulate people, neglect Scripture, or substitute institutional loyalty for faithfulness to Christ. Studying cults should therefore produce humility as well as discernment.

The church's answer to false religion is not merely better argument. It is a community that tells the truth, practices grace, protects the vulnerable, welcomes questions, and visibly lives under the lordship of Jesus Christ.

Conclusion: Test Everything; Hold Fast to What Is Good

The final test

The New Testament does not call Christians to gullibility, and it does not call them to paranoia. It calls them to discernment. Test the spirits. Watch for false teachers. Refuse another gospel. At the same time, love your neighbor, speak truthfully, show gentleness, and remember that only God's grace opens blind eyes—including our own.

The decisive question is not whether a movement is unusual. The decisive question is whether its message is faithful to the God who has revealed himself in Scripture and to the gospel of Jesus Christ.

If anyone brings another gospel, the church must not trade the apostolic Christ for a newer, more impressive substitute. But the people who bring that message remain our neighbors. Christian discernment therefore requires both a firm mind and a compassionate heart.

Selected Source Notes

- Galatians 1:6-9; 2 Corinthians 11:3-4; Acts 20:28-31; 1 John 4:1-3; 2 Peter 2:1-3; Jude 3-4.
- The Church of Jesus Christ of Latter-day Saints, official Topics and Questions: Godhead; Gospel Topics Essays; Book of Mormon materials; Salvation.
- Jehovah's Witnesses, official FAQ and doctrinal materials at JW.org: beliefs about God, Jesus, Trinity, salvation, Kingdom, and 144,000.
- Christian Science, official religious tenets and FAQ at ChristianScience.com.
- Seventh-day Adventist Church, official 28 Fundamental Beliefs, especially Holy Scriptures, Trinity, God the Son, and Experience of Salvation.